

ZHIXIN ZHOU

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EDUCATION

University of Pennsylvania, Philadelphia, PA

08/2024 – Anticipated 05/2026

M.S.Ed Interdisciplinary Studies in Human Development | GPA: 3.90/4.0

Brandeis University, Waltham, MA

09/2020 – 05/2024

B.A. Psychology & Economics | Minors in Education Studies & Math & Music | GPA: 3.848/4.0

Dean's List (every semester)

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Master's Thesis Researcher, Dr. Michael J. Nakkula | University of Pennsylvania, Philadelphia, PA

01/2026 – Present

Examines the emergence of anthropomorphic behaviors in child-AI interactions that signal trust formation and social attribution.

- Analyzed how children interpret **AI as a social partner** through patterns of trust, social attribution, and boundary-setting.
- Developed a **qualitative coding framework** to identify how children ask personal questions, interpret AI responses, and shift from information-seeking toward more social forms of engagement.

Graduate Student Researcher, Dr. Ying Xu: Child-Centered AI Lab | Harvard University, Cambridge, MA

07/2025 – Present

Investigates how conversational AI shapes children's trust, language learning, and social interaction in developmental contexts

Social-Cue Project: Examines how human-like social cues affect children's perception and trust of AI

- Designed **twelve-condition experiment** (human vs. AI voice; with/without social cues) on *Gorilla* to test children's ability to discern AI from human voices.
- Led intensive **behavioral data cleaning** (a total of 10,000+ lines) collected from 30 children, creating secondary annotations to reveal age-related shifts and validate design.
- Optimized **experimental design**, troubleshooting and implementing consistent images and child-friendly voice stimuli.
- Implemented a child-friendly AI perception questionnaire to assess prior exposure and attitudes toward AI technologies.

Curio Project: Explores how children evaluate and trust information from AI compared to human informants

- Coded **6,000+ child-AI dialogues** from 50 children using a home-based AI chatbot for over 2 weeks.
- Characterized children's inquiry and explanation behaviors in AI interactions through iterative codebook development and inter-coder reliability testing.
- Led Stage-2 **pilot launch and data collection** examine children's science learning via interactive AI communication.

Graduate Student Researcher, Dr. Sharon Wolf | University of Pennsylvania, Philadelphia, PA

01/2025 – Present

Studies how early learning environments and education policies influence child development in low-resource settings

- Formulated hypotheses on parenting practices and child behavior using baseline data from 2,476 Ghana adolescents and parents; conducted reliability and correlation analyses to validate constructs.
- Implemented **exploratory (EFA) and confirmatory factor analyses (CFA) model** on the large-scale Ghana data to identify latent parenting-style dimensions with strong model fit and internal consistency.
- Designed culturally adapted survey instruments and informed consent materials for IRB submission.
- Integrated standardized measures of reading and math outcomes to adapt the survey to under-resourced schools.

Graduate Student Researcher, Dr. Xinyin Chen | University of Pennsylvania, Philadelphia, PA

09/2024 – 05/2025

Explores how cultural and social contexts shape children's emotional and social development.

- Conducted systematic **behavioral video coding** across 40 free-play sessions of 172 four-year-old Chinese children, coding key **social-emotional** behaviors into 15 categories including prosocial behavior, sociability, and aggression.

- Built a structured coding dataset and evaluated individual and gender differences in early social behavior.
- Analyzed behavioral indicators of **social anxiety** (fidgeting, avoidance, gaze aversion, speaking duration, smiling) across 25 sessions of 100 UK children presenting birthday experiences, generating quantitative metrics of anxiety expression.
- Designed and refined coding frameworks, ensuring accuracy in behavioral annotation and longitudinal data consistency.

PROFESSIONAL & COMMUNITY EXPERIENCE

Human Resources Internship, World Salon Incorporated | *Remote* 07/2025 – 09/2025

- Directed recruitment for research teams, independently screening 100+ resumes and conducting 20 multi-round interviews.
- Developed KPIs and SOPs to enhance cross-departmental efficiency and onboarding processes.

Teaching Assistant, Lemberg Children's Center | *Waltham, MA* 04/2023 – 05/2024

- Supported social-emotional and cognitive learning for 60 preschoolers through structured play and routine-based activities.
- Led music and story-based sessions to model positive peer interaction and emotional regulation.
- Monitored developmental progress and collaborated with teachers to individualize support plans.

Environmental Musician, Mass General Hospital Cancer Center | *Boston, MA* 01/2024 – 05/2024

- Performed 45-minute therapeutic piano sessions in outpatient care settings to enhance patients' emotional comfort.
- Adapted repertoire in real time to patient responses, creating a calming and responsive environment.

Volunteer, Autism Spectrum Support Program | *Beijing, China; Waltham, MA* 09/2021 – 01/2023

Beijing Stars and Rain Institute for Autism & Waltham Group Spectrum

- Integrated behavioral intervention on 3-year-old children with ASD through communication and family activities.
- Offered weekend support to children with autism through dance, games and other social and recreational activities.

Project Coordinator, Deng Fei Foundation | *Guangzhou, China* 10/2017 – 02/2018; 06/2022 – 08/2022

- Implemented an e-commerce model boosting kiwi and camellia oil sales in rural China, generating sustainable funding for left-behind children's education opportunity.
- Coordinated field investigations with the founder Fei Deng to assess rapeseed yields and optimize farmers' income potential.
- Monitored rapeseed farming and partnered with schools to promote village self-sufficiency through local learning.

SKILLS & TOOLS

- **Research Method:** Mixed-methods Research | Experimental Design | Survey Design | Psychometrics | Behavioral Coding | Thematic Analysis | Codebook Development | Inter-coder Reliability |
- **Analysis:** Python | R | Stata | SPSS | Factor Analysis | Reliability Testing | Correlation Analysis | Regression | Data Visualization | Multivariate Modeling | Econometric Modeling |
- **Design / Logistics:** IRB protocol | Gorilla | ElevenLabs | Survey/Interview Design | Child-Participant Ethics
- **Certifications:** CITI Human Subjects Research (Penn) | CITI Information Privacy & Security (Harvard)
- **Language:** Mandarin Chinese (Native) | English (Fluent)